The Gale Encyclopedia of Medicine: Headache and Pain Management

General Information

Headaches are among the most common physical complaints reported to healthcare practitioners.

Primary headaches include tension headaches, migraines, and cluster headaches without an underlying structural pathology.

Tension-type headaches typically produce a dull, aching sensation across both sides of the forehead or occipital region.

Therapeutic indications

Self-care approaches for mild to moderate tension headaches include rest, hydration, stress management, and mild analgesics

Over-the-counter analgesics such as paracetamol (acetaminophen) and ibuprofen provide effective temporary pain relief.

Special warnings and precautions

Red-flag symptoms require immediate emergency medical evaluation: sudden severe headache (thunderclap headache), headache accompanied by high fever, stiff neck, mental confusion, seizures, double vision, numbness, or speech difficulty.

Headaches following head trauma also necessitate urgent professional assessment.